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UK Mushroom Identifier: A Visual Guide to Common Fungi | Merryhill Mushrooms

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Mushrooms are everywhere once you know where to look. From shady woodlands to grassy verges, the UK is home to an astonishing range of fungi. Some are delicious, some are deadly, and many are just downright odd.

If you have ever spotted one on a walk and thought "Can I eat that?", you are not alone. But when it comes to wild mushrooms, curiosity has to be paired with caution. A handful are safe and edible, but others can make you seriously ill or even be life-threatening.

This guide is designed to help beginners get familiar with some of the most common mushrooms found across the UK. It is not a complete list, and it is definitely not a licence to forage freely, but it will give you a solid starting point. We cover mushrooms that are edible (with caution), toxic species to avoid, and some that are just interesting to know about. We also share safety tips, seasonal advice, and guidance on what to do if you or a pet encounters a wild mushroom.

If you are keen to explore the world of mushrooms, start with observation, not with your plate. And if you are ever in doubt, the safest answer is always: leave it out.

1. Edible mushrooms (with caution)

There are edible wild mushrooms in the UK, but here is the catch: many have toxic lookalikes that grow in the same habitats and seasons. That means even experienced foragers have to be absolutely certain before they pick. Beginners should focus on learning to recognise species first, rather than eating them.

The mushrooms below are commonly foraged and widely considered edible, but only if correctly identified, picked at the right stage, and cooked properly. Always cross-check with a reputable field guide and never rely on a single photo or app.

Field mushroom (*Agaricus campestris*)

You might already know this one. It is the wild cousin of the button mushroom commonly in shops. Field mushrooms grow in grassy areas, often appearing after rainfall from late summer into autumn. The cap is usually white or pale brown and smooth to the touch. Underneath, the gills start out pink and gradually darken to a chocolate brown as the mushroom matures.

Field mushrooms give off that familiar mushroomy scent, and as the name suggests, you will usually find them in playing fields, pastures, or parks.

But take care. The Yellow Stainer, a toxic species covered later in this guide, looks almost identical at first glance. A giveaway is the chemical smell (a bit like ink or disinfectant) and a yellow stain on the base when bruised.



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Agaricus campestris by Alan Rockefeller, via Wikimedia Commons, licensed under CC BY-SA 3.0

Chicken of the Woods (*Laetiporus sulphureus*)

This striking mushroom is hard to miss. Chicken of the Woods grows in large, bright orange and yellow shelf-like clusters on the trunks of living or dead trees, particularly oak, chestnut, and willow. It is most commonly found in late spring through autumn, especially after rainy spells.

As the name suggests, this wild mushroom has a meaty texture and a mild, savoury flavour that is often compared to chicken, making it a favourite among vegetarians and foragers alike. When young and fresh, the flesh is tender and succulent, ideal for frying, grilling, or adding to stews.

However, caution is key. Always harvest from hardwoods. Specimens growing on conifers or eucalyptus may cause stomach upset. Also, try a small portion first, as some people experience mild digestive issues even with properly identified Chicken of the Woods.

Look for smooth, velvety caps with vibrant colour and no signs of drying or decay. Older mushrooms become tough and lose their culinary appeal, so it is best to harvest them young and cook them thoroughly.



Mikebishop21, via Wikimedia Commons, licensed under CC BY-SA 4.0

Chanterelle (*Cantharellus cibarius*)

Chanterelles are among the most recognisable and sought-after wild mushrooms in the UK. They stand out with their golden-yellow colour, wavy edges, and ridges (rather than true gills) that run down the stem. You will usually catch a gentle fruity scent if you pick one up. Some say they smell like apricots.

They grow in mossy woodland, particularly under beech and birch, and often appear in the same places year after year.

However, do not confuse them with the False Chanterelle, which is a deeper orange and has thinner, more gill-like structures underneath. That one can cause stomach upset if eaten.





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Shaggy Inkcap (*Coprinus comatus*)

You will often see these growing in grassy verges or disturbed ground in late summer and autumn. When young, they have a tall, white, cylindrical cap covered in shaggy scales. They almost look like they are wearing an old woolly jumper. As they age, they dissolve into a black inky mess (hence the name).

They are edible when young and firm, but once the black ink starts to appear, they are past their best. Some inkcaps also react badly with alcohol, so it is worth being cautious.



Bigredwine1, via Wikimedia Commons, licensed under CC BY-SA 4.0

Porcini / Cep (*Boletus edulis*)

Thick, chunky, and easy to miss among fallen leaves, the **porcini** is a favourite among chefs. You will find them in broadleaf woodlands, particularly under oak or beech. The cap is brown and smooth, whilst the underside has a spongy layer instead of gills. Their stem is fat and often patterned with a net-like texture.

Porcini mushrooms smell slightly nutty and are considered one of the safest mushrooms to eat if you are confident in your identification.

But, and it is a big but, some other *Boletus* species are bitter or toxic, especially those with red or orange pores or ones that stain blue when cut or bruised.



Bernard Spragg, NZ from Christchurch, New Zealand, CC0, via Wikimedia Commons

Parasol mushroom (*Macrolepiota procera*)

If you see a huge mushroom standing tall like a dinner plate on a stalk, you might be looking at a parasol. They can reach up to 30cm wide and often grow in grasslands or on woodland edges. The cap is scaly with a raised central bump, and the long stem has a snakeskin-like pattern.

These mushrooms are considered a good edible, but they also have lookalikes. The Shaggy Parasol, for instance, causes stomach upset in some people, and smaller *Lepiota* species can be toxic.

As impressive as they look, parasols should only be picked by those with solid identification experience.





Norbert Nagel, via Wikimedia Commons, licensed under CC BY-SA 3.0

2. Toxic and deadly mushrooms

Some of the UK's most **dangerous mushrooms** do not look particularly threatening, which is exactly what makes them so risky. Many grow in the same environments as edible species and can appear almost identical at first glance.

Below are five you should be able to recognise, if only to avoid them. If you have pets, these species are equally dangerous to cats and dogs. Our guide on **whether cats and dogs can eat mushrooms** covers what to do if a pet encounters a wild mushroom.

Death cap (*Amanita phalloides*)

This is the most toxic mushroom in the UK and is responsible for the majority of fatal mushroom poisonings worldwide. Even a small amount can cause liver failure, and cooking will not destroy the poison. It tends to grow beneath oak and beech trees in late summer to autumn.

It looks ordinary: pale green or yellowish cap, white gills, and a bulbous base often hidden underground. The gills do not turn brown with age, which is a helpful way to distinguish it from edible agarics like the field mushroom.

Symptoms of death cap poisoning can be delayed by 6 to 24 hours, and there is often a "false recovery" where the person or animal appears to improve before liver failure sets in. If you suspect anyone (or any pet) has eaten a death cap, seek emergency medical or veterinary help immediately.



George Chernilevsky, Public domain, via Wikimedia Commons, licensed under CC BY 4.0

Fly agaric (*Amanita muscaria*)

With its bright red cap and white spots, this one is straight out of a storybook, but it is not to be eaten. Fly agaric contains psychoactive compounds that can cause nausea, confusion, and hallucinations.

It is most commonly found under birch and pine trees and tends to appear in autumn. Although some cultures have historically used it, in the UK it is best admired, not consumed. It is also dangerous to pets, particularly dogs, who may be attracted to it during autumn walks.





Holger Krisp, CC BY 3.0, via Wikimedia Commons

Yellow Stainer (*Agaricus xanthodermus*)

This one is dangerous because it is so easily confused with edible field mushrooms. It looks almost the same: white cap, brown gills. But it bruises yellow near the base and gives off a strong chemical smell, a bit like ink or disinfectant.

Found in gardens, parks, and fields, it is one of the most common causes of mushroom-related stomach upsets in the UK. While it is rarely fatal, it can cause severe nausea, vomiting, and stomach cramps.



frankenstoen, CC BY 2.0, via Wikimedia Commons

Funeral Bell (*Galerina marginata*)

This small brown mushroom grows on dead wood and tree stumps, often in clusters. It might not catch your eye, but it contains the same deadly toxins (amatoxins) as the death cap.

It is easily mistaken for edible wood-loving mushrooms like Velvet Shank, which makes it particularly dangerous to foragers who are not experienced with wood-growing species.



Elizabeth Axley, via Wikimedia Commons, licensed under CC BY 4.0

Fool's funnel (*Clitocybe rivulosa*)

This small white mushroom is sometimes found in fairy rings on lawns or grassy areas. It has a funnel-shaped cap and crowded white gills. It only grows to around 6cm tall, making it easy to overlook.

Despite its innocent look, the Fool's Funnel contains muscarine, a toxin that can cause sweating, nausea, blurred vision, breathing difficulties, and a dangerously slow heart rate in larger amounts. It is one of the most common poisonous mushrooms found on UK lawns, which makes it a particular risk for pet owners. If you find these growing in your garden, remove them promptly.





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3. Inedible or easily mistaken mushrooms

Not all wild mushrooms are harmful, but that does not mean they are good to eat. Some are too tough, bitter, or odd-smelling to be considered edible. Others look just enough like edible species to cause confusion. Here are a few you are likely to spot around the UK that fall into that middle ground.

Earthball (*Scleroderma citrinum*)

These round, brown fungi often look like puffballs at first glance, but they are not the same. Earthballs have a tough skin and a dark, spore-filled interior. They grow in woods and on heathland and can cause stomach upset if eaten.



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Stinkhorn (*Phallus impudicus*)

A mushroom you will smell before you see. Stinkhorns emerge from a jelly-like egg and grow into tall, white stems topped with a brown, foul-smelling cap. The odour attracts flies, which help spread the spores. Found in woodland and gardens, typically from late summer through autumn.



Stu's Images, via Wikimedia Commons, licensed under CC BY-SA 4.0

Fairy Inkcap (*Coprinellus disseminatus*)

These delicate, greyish mushrooms grow in large clusters on rotting wood. They look magical, but they are not considered edible. Too fragile and insubstantial to bother with.





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Common Puffball (*Lycoperdon perlatum*)

Edible when young and white inside, but only if you know exactly what you are picking. Once mature, they release a puff of brown spores. Beginners often confuse them with earthballs, so unless you are confident, best to leave them.



Stu's Images, via Wikimedia Commons, licensed under CC BY-SA 4.0

Where mushrooms grow: spotting by habitat

The mushrooms in this guide grow in a mix of environments, from open fields and woodland trails to roadside verges and shady garden corners. Paying attention to where a mushroom appears can offer valuable clues about its identity, especially when shape and colour alone are not enough.

Grassland and lawns: Field mushrooms, parasol mushrooms, Fool's Funnel, and Yellow Stainers are all commonly found in open grassy areas including your own garden. Fool's Funnel is particularly common on well-kept lawns and in parks, which is worth knowing if you have children or pets.

Broadleaf woodland (oak, beech, birch): This is where you will find chanterelles, porcini, death caps, and fly agaric. Many of these species form symbiotic relationships with specific tree roots, so if you know the trees, you can start to predict which fungi might appear nearby.

Coniferous woodland (pine, spruce): Destroying angel, false morel, and some Funeral Bell specimens are found in or near coniferous woodland. Check carefully around tree stumps and fallen logs.

Dead wood and tree stumps: Chicken of the Woods, Funeral Bell, and Fairy Inkcap all grow on dead or dying wood. Some species appear on standing dead trees, others on fallen logs or buried roots.

Gardens and disturbed ground: Shaggy Inkcap, earthball, stinkhorn, and common puffball can all appear in gardens, compost heaps, and areas of disturbed soil. Keep an eye out after rain, as many species can appear overnight.

When to look: mushroom season in the UK

The peak season for wild mushrooms in the UK is autumn, roughly September to

November. This is when the majority of species fruit, driven by cooler temperatures and increased rainfall. However, some species appear earlier or later depending on the weather.

Spring (March to May): False morels and St George's mushrooms can appear in spring, particularly in mild, damp conditions.

Summer (June to August): Chicken of the Woods often appears from late spring through summer. Field mushrooms and chanterelles can start appearing from July onwards if conditions are right.

Autumn (September to November): This is peak season. The majority of species covered in this guide, including porcini, fly agaric, death cap, parasol, Funeral Bell, and Fool's Funnel, are most abundant during this period.

Winter (December to February): Mushroom activity drops significantly, but Velvet Shank and some bracket fungi can persist through mild winters. Stinkhorn eggs may also be found year-round in woodland soil.

Mild, wet spells at any time of year can trigger unexpected fruiting, so it pays to stay observant throughout the seasons, especially if you have pets that spend time in the garden or on woodland walks.

Tips for safe identification

Mushrooms can be tricky to tell apart. Here are some principles that will help keep you safe.

Check multiple features, not just the cap. Look at the gills (or pores), the stem, the base, the colour when bruised, the smell, and where it is growing. Many toxic species can only be distinguished from edible ones by a combination of features.

Do not rely on apps alone. Mushroom identification apps can be useful as a starting point, but they are not reliable enough to trust with your safety. They frequently misidentify species, especially when working from a single photograph. Always cross-reference with a reputable printed field guide.

When in doubt, leave it out. This is the single most important rule. No meal is worth the risk of serious poisoning. If you cannot identify a mushroom with absolute certainty, do not pick it and do not eat it.

Never eat a wild mushroom raw. Even species that are considered edible should be cooked thoroughly before eating. Cooking breaks down compounds that can cause digestive issues in many species. For more on **which mushrooms can be eaten raw** (shop-bought varieties, not wild ones), see our separate guide.

Learn from experts, not just the internet. Local foraging walks led by experienced mycologists are the best way to build real identification skills. Many wildlife trusts and fungi groups run events during autumn.

Keep pets away from wild mushrooms. Cats and dogs cannot tell the difference between safe and toxic species, and some of the most dangerous mushrooms (like the death cap) have a fishy odour that dogs find attractive. If your pet eats a wild mushroom, contact your vet immediately. Our guide on **mushrooms and pet safety** covers this in detail, including emergency steps and the UK Animal PoisonLine number.

We do not advocate the picking of wild mushrooms unless you are absolutely sure and confident with the identification process. Always consult an expert if you are uncertain.

A safer way to enjoy mushrooms

Mushroom spotting is a brilliant way to connect with nature, but when it comes to eating them, caution is key. If you would prefer to enjoy mushrooms without the risk of misidentification, try growing your own at home. Our ready-growing mushroom kits use commercially cultivated, food-safe species and give you a first harvest in days rather than weeks. No foraging knowledge required.

[Browse Growing Kits](#)

Frequently asked questions

How do I identify a poisonous mushroom in the UK?

There is no single rule that separates all poisonous mushrooms from safe ones. You need to check multiple features: the cap shape and colour, the gills or pores, the stem, the base, any colour change when bruised, the smell, and the habitat. Many toxic species closely resemble edible ones. The safest approach is to learn a small number of species thoroughly rather than trying to identify everything you find. When in doubt, do not pick it.

Are mushrooms growing on my lawn poisonous?

They might be. Lawn mushrooms are wild mushrooms, and some toxic species (particularly Fool's Funnel) commonly grow on well-kept lawns and in parks. Unless you can identify a lawn mushroom with certainty, treat it as potentially dangerous. If you have children or pets, remove any mushrooms that appear in your garden promptly.

When is mushroom season in the UK?

Peak mushroom season in the UK is autumn, roughly September to November. However, some species appear earlier (Chicken of the Woods from late spring, chanterelles from July) and mild, damp conditions at any time of year can trigger unexpected fruiting. If you are concerned about pets encountering wild mushrooms, stay alert from late summer right through to the first frosts.

Can I use an app to identify mushrooms?

Mushroom identification apps can be a helpful starting point for learning, but they are not reliable enough to trust with your safety. They frequently misidentify species, especially from single photographs or when a mushroom is at an unusual stage of growth. Always cross-reference with a reputable printed field guide and, ideally, learn from an experienced forager or mycologist in person.

What should I do if I eat a wild mushroom and feel unwell?

Seek medical help immediately. Call 111 or go to A&E if symptoms are severe. If possible, collect a sample of the mushroom (or take a clear photograph showing the cap, gills, and stem) and bring it with you. Do not wait to see if symptoms get worse, as some of the most dangerous mushrooms cause delayed symptoms that can initially seem mild before progressing to organ failure.

Are wild mushrooms dangerous for cats and dogs?

Yes. The same species that are toxic to humans are toxic to pets. Some, like the death cap, have a slightly fishy odour that dogs find attractive. If your pet eats a wild mushroom, treat it as an emergency and contact your vet or the Animal PoisonLine on 01202 509 000 immediately. For full guidance, see our article on [whether cats and dogs can eat mushrooms](#).

What is the most dangerous mushroom in the UK?

The death cap (*Amanita phalloides*) is the most dangerous mushroom in the UK. It is responsible for the majority of fatal mushroom poisonings and can cause irreversible liver failure from even a small amount. It grows in broadleaf woodland, particularly near oak and beech, and appears from late summer to autumn.

Is it safe to grow mushrooms at home instead of foraging?

Yes. **Home growing kits** use commercially cultivated, food-safe species that are the same varieties sold in supermarkets. There is no risk of misidentification because you know exactly what species you are growing. It is the safest and simplest way to enjoy fresh mushrooms at home.

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